



CAREER PATHWAYS ADVANCEMENT PROJECT 2.0

Evaluation Brief Series

Overview of the Career Advancement Model Demonstration Evaluation Approach

By Shahrzad Sajadi and Kelly Haines

Introduction

Beginning in 2015, the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) at the University of Massachusetts Boston has been the independent evaluator of the Nebraska Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) Career Pathways Advancement Project (CPAP). Nebraska VR first piloted the CPAP model as one of four state VR agency grantees funded by the Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA) to carry out a 5-year Career Pathways for Individuals with Disabilities demonstration project (known as “CPAP 1.0”). Building on the success of the CPAP 1.0 model, in 2021, Nebraska VR received a second model demonstration grant funded by the RSA to expand the CPAP model (known as “CPAP 2.0”) for an additional five years.

The CPAP 1.0 used a career pathways approach to help VR clients acquire skills and credentials necessary to advance into high demand, high-quality jobs with higher wages and employer-provided benefits. The CPAP 1.0 used an “upskill/backfill” approach to support past VR clients and incumbent workers advance in their careers in five targeted career clusters:

(1) Information Technology (IT); (2) Manufacturing; (3) Transportation, Distribution, & Logistics (TDL); (4) Healthcare; and (5) Architecture/Construction. [Read about CPAP 1.0 outcomes](#) and visit the [Career Pathways toolkit](#) to learn more about the project.

This first brief in the CPAP 2.0 series provides an overview of the approach and methods used to evaluate Nebraska VR’s CPAP 2.0 model demonstration project. Subsequent briefs will include implementation and evolution of the model, client and business experience, and outcome measures and results.

An Overview of the CPAP 2.0 Model

Nebraska VR launched the CPAP 2.0 model and expanded both their target population and the number of targeted industries and businesses across the state. By expanding the target population and industries, Nebraska has been able to test the project’s applicability to a broader range of clients who reflect the population Nebraska VR serves.

Project Goals

CPAP 2.0 has four main goals:

1. Increase the internal and state-system capacity to provide coordinated, collaborative career advancement services that build upon Nebraska’s career pathways models.
2. Expand the target population by contacting 2,932 individuals receiving career advancement services to include previously served VR clients who receive Supplemental Security Income (SSI) and/or Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI), previously served VR clients who closed into low-wage occupations, previously served VR clients who closed into high-demand sectors with likelihood of growth, past CPAP participants, and incumbent workers.
3. Increase access to training opportunities that provide the credentials necessary to obtain promotional opportunities and advance in a formal career series with a current employer or a different employer in pathways of Administrative Support; Construction; Healthcare Science



Support and Therapeutic Services; Lodging; Manufacturing; Professional Sales; Restaurant & Food Beverage Service; and Transportation, Distribution, and Logistics (TDL).

4. Strengthen business engagement through contacts with 400 businesses statewide by increasing business relationships. Additionally, support clients to obtain credentials, increase their wages, and access employer-provided benefits for economic self-sufficiency.

Targeted Outcomes of CPAP 2.0

Through CPAP 2.0, Nebraska VR hopes to meet the following standards:

\$18 per hour

Participants earn an average hourly wage of \$18.00 per hour at the time of exit in competitive integrated employment (CIE)

40 hours per week

Participants work an average of 40 hours per week at the time of exit in CIE

87% with employer - provided medical benefits

Number and percentage of participants who exit in CIE with employer - provided medical benefits is 87%

100% reporting personal wages as primary source

Number and percentage of participants who report their personal wages as the primary source of support at the time of exit in CIE is 100%

0% reporting public benefits as primary source

Number and percentage of participants who report public benefits (e.g., SSI, SSDI, Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF), and state or local benefits) as their primary source of support at the time of exit in CIE is 0%

How Will ICI Evaluate the CPAP 2.0 Model?

For projects of this scope, the ICI's evaluation approach includes four core components:

(1) *Process Evaluation*, (2) *Fidelity Assessment*, (3) *Outcome Evaluation*, and (4) *Progress Reporting*.

Process Evaluation

Process Evaluation helps determine how specific elements of a project may affect outcomes. The goal of the process evaluation is to document the implementation of the project design over time and assess the use of resources and progress toward objectives. To inform the process evaluation, we review the documents produced by the project. We also review and analyze the data of the deidentified case records for CPAP 2.0 and non-CPAP 2.0 clients. Additionally, we meet with the CPAP 2.0 team on a quarterly basis to hear updates of progress toward the project goals and explore any discussion points arising from the data. These meetings allow us to get a clearer picture of the project and understand the context in which the project is unfolding.

Fidelity Assessment

The Fidelity Assessment method determines how Nebraska VR's implementation strategies align with CPAP 2.0's Upskill/Backfill model. Together with the process evaluation, these methods describe the context in which the model was implemented. Several members of the ICI team travel to the CPAP 2.0 site every year, meet with the staff, conduct group conversations, and observe the process to understand the project's alignment with the fidelity instrument. There are three parts of the fidelity assessment:

1. **Defining the core elements of program.** This part of the fidelity assessment defines and refines elements of the program to explore major changes, discontinuation, or any major development. This part also explores each element of the program compared to business as usual.
2. **Measurement.** This part of the fidelity assessment explores how we measure and assess each element of the program and explores the best source of data to do so.
3. **Sustainability/Replicability/Transferability.** This part of the fidelity assessment evaluates the sustainability of each element of the program and explores the resources that might support its continuation.

Outcome Evaluation

The Outcome Evaluation component is designed to document the relationship between project participation and the project's goals and objectives. The outcome evaluation consists of several elements, including data review and secondary analysis, pre-post surveys to understand the knowledge gains of staff who have taken the Career Pathways trainings, and a series of satisfaction surveys and in-depth qualitative interviews of the CPAP 2.0 clients. The pre-post surveys aim to understand the CPAP 2.0 team's understanding of the Career Pathways trainings with the goal of addressing any gaps in knowledge. The surveys and interviews are designed to understand the CPAP 2.0 clients' perspectives of the CPAP 2.0 and its impact on their lives. We will discuss the findings from the interviews in future briefs.

Progress Reporting

Progress Reporting describes the collaboration between Nebraska VR and ICI to create quarterly and annual reports to satisfy the requirements of the funding agency (RSA) for each project year of the grant. This component collates all the data from the other components into written reports. The progress reports include recommendations for adjustments in response to implementation challenges.

Evaluation Approach

Design: Four-prong evaluation documents the relationship between program participation and targeted outcomes

Process Evaluation

- Document review
- Monthly/Quarterly videoconferences
- Administrative data review

Fidelity Assessment

- Self-Assessments
- In-person site visits
- Pre-Post Tests of Knowledge Gains (staff/provider)

Outcome Evaluation

- Administrative data
- Job seeker and Business surveys
- Qualitative interviews

Progress Reporting

- Annual Evaluation Reports
- Alignment with other reporting requirements

Future briefs in this series will explore these components further and look at key outcomes and lessons learned.

Review VR is a publication of ExploreVR, the data hub for a group of vocational rehabilitation research projects at the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

The contents of this brief were developed by the ICI as part of a partnership under grant Award: H421C210021 from the US Department of Education to Nebraska Vocational Rehabilitation. However, these contents do not necessarily represent the policy of the Department of Education, and readers should not assume endorsement by the Federal Government. (Authority: 20 U.S.C. 1221e-3 and 3474)

FOR MORE INFORMATION: Kelly.Haines@umb.edu

VISIT: [Nebraska VR's CPAP website](#) to learn more about this effort.

ACCESS: [ICI's Career Pathways Toolkit](#)



www.exploreVR.org